THE HUNT FOR THE BISMARCK

On May 18, 1941, the battleship *Bismarck*, accompanied by the cruiser *Prinz Eugen* sailed from the Baltic port of Gdynia. Admiral Lütjens' mission was to break out into the Atlantic and raid Allied merchant convoys. The Royal Navy tracked the ships as far as the Norwegian coast, after which they disappeared. On the evening of May 23, however, the pair were detected by the radar-equipped cruisers *Norfolk* and *Suffolk,* on patrol in the Denmark Strait.

SINKING OF THE HOOD

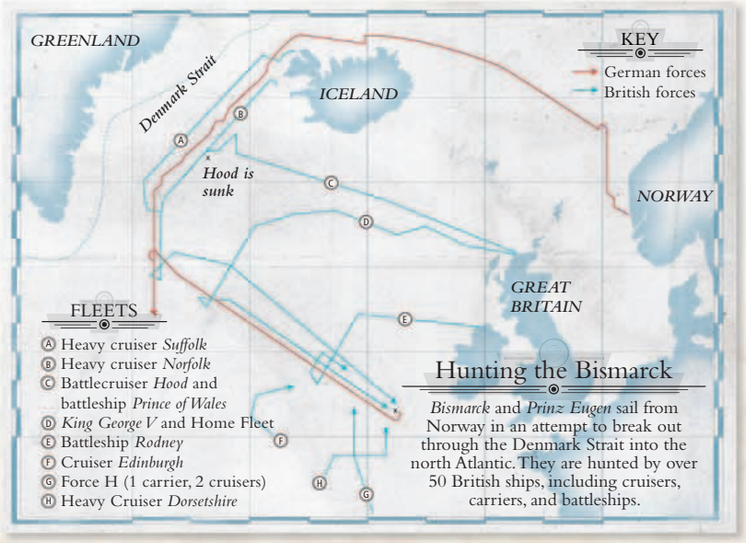
The new battleship *Prince of Wales* and the large but aging battlecruiser *Hood* arrived in visual range at 5:35 a.m. the next morning. On paper the two sides looked well matched, but *Prince of Wales* had been rushed into action without proper preparation, while *Hood* lacked adequate armor. *Bismarck,* while not without flaw, was the largest warship commissioned at the time. The firing began at range, with the Royal Navy ships closing rapidly. At 6:00 a.m. a shell penetrated one of *Hood*'s magazines and the battlecruiser was split in two by a huge explosion. It sank in three minutes. Only three men from a crew of over 1,400 survived. The *Prince of Wales* prudently broke off the fight. The sinking of *Hood* was a severe shock to the Royal Navy, but *Bismarck* had not emerged unscathed. A shell had damaged its fuel tanks, forcing Lütjens to alter his plans. *Prinz Eugen* was despatched to fulfil the commerce raiding mission, while *Bismarck* made a dash for Brittany.

The Royal Navy devoted every available resource to hunting down the German battleship, but Admiral John Tovey, leading the pursuit on board *King George V,* found the enemy elusive. A torpedo attack by Swordfish aircraft from the carrier *Victorious* on the night of May 24 was ineffectual and the following day Lütjens gave his pursuers the slip. Tovey mistakenly suspected he was heading back to the Denmark Strait and sailed too far north.

THE END OF THE BISMARCK

On the morning of May 26 *Bismarck*'s luck changed, when she was spotted by a Catalina flying boat of RAF Coastal Command. Tovey was too far off to catch *Bismarck* before she came within the protective shelter of land-based Luftwaffe aircraft. But Force H, including the carrier *Ark Royal*, sailing north from Gibraltar, was well placed to intercept. The Force's commander, Admiral James Sommerville, sent the cruiser *Sheffield* to shadow *Bismarck* and Swordfish from *Ark Royal* to attack with torpedoes. The first Swordfish sortie was a fiasco—they attacked *Sheffield* by mistake. But a second sortie late in the day proved decisive. Flying unscathed through a barrage of anti-aircraft fire in the murky dusk, the flimsy biplanes managed two hits on *Bismarck*, one of which jammed the rudders. The ship was stuck in a circle to port. Realizing that he was now doomed, Lütjens sent a last message to headquarters: "We will fight to the last shell. Long live the Führer!"

British destroyers kept up the pressure on *Bismarck* through the night with torpedo attacks. The following morning the battleships *King George V* and *Rodney* arrived to batter Lütjens' crippled ship. *Bismarck* was a burning hulk by the time the cruiser *Dorsetshire* closed to finish her off with torpedoes. Only 110 of the crew were saved.





WORLD WAR II

HUNT FOR THE BISMARCK

Date	May 18–27, 1941
Location	North Atlantic
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

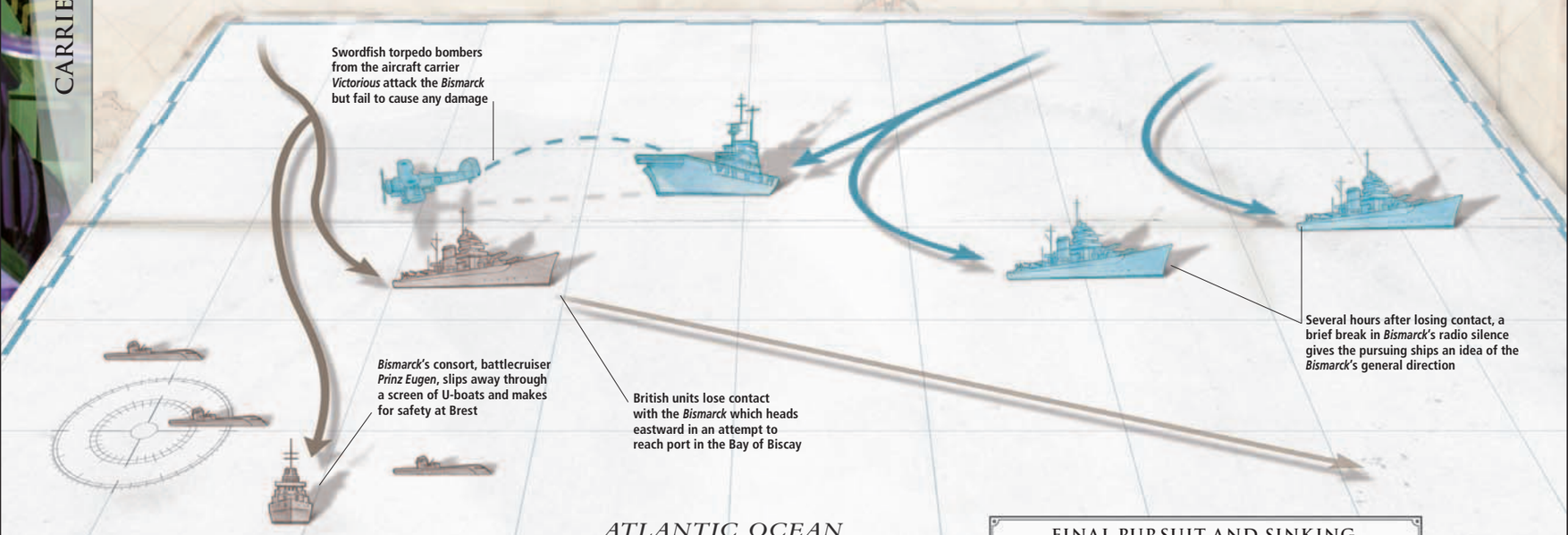
John Tovey	Günther Lütjens

FORCES

Ships: 2 carriers, 7 battleships, more than 50 other ships	**Ships:** 1 battleship, 1 cruiser

LOSSES

Men: 1,500 **Ships:** 1 battlecruiser	**Men:** 2,100 **Ships:** 1 battleship



FINAL PURSUIT AND SINKING

1 THE BRITISH LOSE CONTACT

Following the sinking of the HMS *Hood* in the Denmark Strait, the British commit every available unit to hunting down the now limping *Bismarck*. However the British ships lose contact with their quarry and for a time it seems likely that the *Bismarck* may escape.